Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

October 8, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S29 – 2001 Model Year United States Postal Service Stripped Chassis

Summary

- Ford Action – Ford is conducting a safety recall involving 2001 Model Year United States Postal Service (USPS) Stripped Chassis built from August 18, 2000 to February 15, 2001.

- Number of Vehicles Involved – Approximately 7,306 vehicles (all with the United States Postal Service).

- Affect on Vehicle Operation – Fasteners for suspension mounting brackets located on the left and right frame rail may not have been properly installed resulting in either loose or missing fasteners. The presence of loose or missing fasteners may result in noise from the front of the vehicle in normal driving. Low speed maneuverability may be moderately affected, primarily due to an increase in body roll. Engineering evaluations at higher speeds indicate a degradation in limit handling capability and would not satisfy Ford's criteria. There have been no accidents or injuries due to this condition.

- Service Procedure – Dealers will inspect for damaged bushings and brackets and proper fastener torques for all vehicles built during this time period. Damaged components will be replaced and the fasteners will be properly torqued.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S29 5d/sls

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S29 -- 2001 MODEL YEAR UNITED STATES POSTAL SERVICE STRIPPED CHASSIS

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

- Certain 2001 model year United States Postal Service (USPS) Stripped Chassis built from August 18, 2000 to February 15, 2001.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

The stripped chassis were manufactured for Ford by Trumack Assembly L.L.C. (refered to as Trumack) 6501 Lynch Roach, Detroit, MI. The plant number is NA13. Jody Walzak, Trumack's point of contact, can be reached at 765-429-1966.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 7,306 vehicles

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown

573.5 (c) (5) --Description of the Defect

Fasteners for suspension mounting brackets located on the left and right frame rail may not have been properly installed resulting in either loose or missing fasteners. The presence of loose or missing fasteners may result in noise from the front of the vehicle in normal driving. Low speed maneuverability may be moderately affected, primarily due to an increase in body roll. Engineering evaluations at higher speeds indicate a degradation in limit handling capability and would not satisfy Ford's criteria. There have been no accidents or injuries due to this condition.

Ford is unaware of any reports of accidents or injuries as a result of the condition.

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573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

On February 15, 2001, it was reported to Ford Engineering that a USPS driver in North Carolina experienced a loud noise coming from the front end of the vehicle. Upon inspection it was found that fasteners were missing from a suspension mounting bracket on the right hand side of the frame rail. Other vehicles in the fleet were examined and found to have loose or missing fasteners. On February 16, 2001, additional operations were added at both Trumack and at Utilimaster (the final stage manufacturer) to verify the proper installation of the bolts. On April 26, 2001, a similar incident was reported on two units at a Deluth, Georgia USPS facility. These vehicles also had fasteners missing on the right hand side. Upon inspection of this fleet, additional vehicles were found with fasteners missing or loose. Throughout the summer, Ford Engineering conducted an extensive vehicle dynamics evaluation including various combinations of fasteners on both sides either loose or missing to determine the potential effects of the condition.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford currently anticipates that the United States Postal Service notification will occur on or before the week of November 8, 2001.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Notices to dealers and the United States Postal Service from Ford Customer Service Division will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S29 to this action.